

2026 March Madness Bracket Strategy & Methodology

The Complete Bracket-Picking Framework

PART 1: THE METHODOLOGY — How to Think About Picking a Bracket

Step 1: Start With the Data, Not Your Gut

The single best predictor of NCAA tournament success is **KenPom Adjusted Efficiency Margin** — the gap between a team's points scored and points allowed per 100 possessions, adjusted for opponent strength.

The Championship Formula (backed by 23 years of data): - 22 of the last 23 national champions ranked **top 25 in BOTH** adjusted offensive AND defensive efficiency - All 24 of the last 24 champions ranked **top 25** in adjusted efficiency margin - The lone exception: UConn 2014 (No. 39 offense, No. 10 defense)

2026 teams that fit the Championship Formula (top 21 offense + top 31 defense): Duke, Illinois, Arizona, Vanderbilt, Michigan, Florida, Houston, Louisville, Iowa State

Step 2: Apply Historical Seed Performance Data

Use these historical upset rates to calibrate your picks:

Matchup	Higher Seed Win %	Key Insight
1 vs 16	~99%	Only 2 upsets ever (UMBC 2018, FDU 2023)
2 vs 15	~93%	~11 upsets all-time
3 vs 14	~86%	Roughly 1 upset per year
4 vs 13	~79%	~1 upset per year
5 vs 12	~64%	THE classic upset spot — 36% upset rate
6 vs 11	~61%	11-seeds have been winning MORE since 2016
7 vs 10	~61%	Essentially a toss-up
8 vs 9	~49%	9-seeds actually lead historically

Rules of thumb: - Pick ALL four 1-seeds to win Round 1 - Pick at least ONE 12-over-5 upset (has happened in 34 of last 40 tournaments) - Pick at least ONE 11-over-6 upset (has happened every year since 2005) - Treat 8-vs-9 as a coin flip — use matchup analysis, not seeding - Pick 1-2 upsets in the 3-vs-14 or 4-vs-13 range

Step 3: Evaluate Championship Viability by Seed

Who actually wins titles: - 1-seeds: ~65% of championships (26 of 40 since 1985) - 2-seeds: Second most common - 3-seeds: Occasional (UConn 2011, Syracuse 2003) - 7-seed UConn 2014 is the lowest seed to win since 8-seed Villanova in 1985 - **No team seeded 9 or lower has EVER reached the championship game**

Your champion should be a 1, 2, or 3 seed. Period.

Step 4: Check Injury Reports

Injuries are the single biggest source of bracket-busting variance. A team missing a key player is significantly more vulnerable, regardless of seed.

Step 5: Factor in Coaching Experience

Tournament coaching experience matters enormously in close games. Coaches who have been to multiple Final Fours consistently outperform in high-pressure situations.

Step 6: Consider Playing Style Matchups

What does NOT predict success: - Tempo (champions come at all paces) - Non-conference strength of schedule - "Luck" rating

What DOES predict tournament runs: - Defensive efficiency (defense travels) - Rebounding - Free throw shooting (games are tight, FTs decide them) - 3-point shooting (can fuel runs or cause cold-shooting exits) - Experience/upperclassmen (Cinderellas often have veteran rosters) - Cinderellas tend to play SLOW (average tempo rank: 168th)

Step 7: Check Geographic Advantages

Since the pod system was introduced in 2002, **teams playing first-round games in their home states win over 80% of the time (33-8)**. College basketball has the most significant home-court advantage of any major sport — worth 3-4 points.

2026 geographic edges: - Cal Baptist is only 88 miles from the San Diego pod (vs. Kansas) - Florida is 118 miles from the Tampa pod - Missouri plays in St. Louis (essentially a home game vs. Miami FL) - Houston has HOME COURT for Sweet 16/Elite 8 (South Region) - St. John's has the worst travel burden: 2,444 miles to San Diego across 3 time zones

Step 8: Apply the Upset Vulnerability Checklist

Factor	Red Flag for Higher Seed
Tempo	Plays slow (outside top 200 in tempo)
Defense	Poor defensive efficiency despite elite offense
Free Throws	Shoots poorly from the line
3PT Dependence	Lives and dies by the three
Injuries	Missing key players
Geography	Traveling far from home
Depth	Thin rotation in compressed schedule
Quad 1 Record	Weak record vs. top competition
Conf. Tourney	Lost early in conference tournament

The ideal upset candidate has: Elite eFG%, low turnover rate, strong offensive rebounding, hot 3PT shooting, late-season momentum, and strong free throw shooting.

PART 2: THE 2026 BRACKET — Region-by-Region Analysis

2026 No. 1 Seeds

Seed	Team	Region	KenPom	Odds
1	Duke	East	#1 (Off #4, Def #2)	+350
1	Michigan	Midwest	#2 (Off #8, Def #1)	+370
1	Arizona	West	#3 (Off #5, Def #3)	+380
1	Florida	South	#4 (Off #9, Def #6)	+750

EAST REGION (Duke's Region)

Seed	Team	vs	Seed	Team
1	Duke	vs	16	Siena
8	Ohio State	vs	9	TCU
5	St. John's	vs	12	Northern Iowa
4	Kansas	vs	13	Cal Baptist
6	Louisville	vs	11	South Florida
3	Michigan State	vs	14	North Dakota State
7	UCLA	vs	10	UCF
2	UConn	vs	15	Furman

Analysis: This is the TOUGHEST region. Duke has the hardest path despite being the #1 overall seed. UConn and Michigan State are both KenPom-certified championship contenders, and Kansas is a rugged 4-seed.

Key factors: - Duke is missing Caleb Foster (fractured foot, likely out entire tournament) and Patrick Ngongba II (questionable). This significantly weakens their perimeter defense. - UConn is a dangerous 2-seed with championship pedigree (back-to-back titles in 2023-24). - St. John's won the Big East regular season AND tournament — they're underseeded at 5. - South Florida (11) is a popular upset pick over Louisville (6). USF has 6 of its top 7 scorers as upperclassmen. Won 17 of last 19 including 11 straight. - Louisville went 4-8 in final 12 games vs. Quad 1 opponents — fading badly. - Northern Iowa (12) ranks 363rd in adjusted tempo (3rd slowest in D-I) but has the 24th-best defense. Fewer possessions = more variance. A classic Cinderella profile. - Cal Baptist (13) has only an 88-mile drive to the San Diego pod — near-home court vs. Kansas (2,444 miles for St. John's going the other way).

Recommended picks: - Duke advances to the Final Four — even without Foster, Boozer (22.7/10.2/4.2, 41% from 3) is the best player in the region - St. John's is underseeded — pick them to beat Kansas and make the Sweet 16 (Pitino in March + Big East double champ) - South Florida over Louisville (11 over 6 upset — USF has won 17 of 19, Louisville 4-8 in Q1). Note: USF's streak was against weaker opponents (avg NET 158), so this is a genuine toss-up. - UCLA's Bilodeau and Dent are EXPECTED TO PLAY (sat out Big Ten tourney as precaution). UCLA over UCF. - **Region winner: Duke** (32-2, Boozer is transcendent — 39 of 60 ESPN experts agree)

WEST REGION (Arizona's Region)

Seed	Team	vs	Seed	Team
1	Arizona	vs	16	LIU
8	Villanova	vs	9	Utah State
5	Wisconsin	vs	12	High Point
4	Arkansas	vs	13	Hawaii
6	BYU	vs	11	Texas/NC State
3	Gonzaga	vs	14	Kennesaw State
7	Miami (FL)	vs	10	Missouri
2	Purdue	vs	15	Queens

Analysis: Arizona has the cleanest path of any 1-seed. They're the healthiest top team, don't rely on 3-point shooting, and have elite size/physicality. The Wildcats beat 12 ranked teams this season (tied with Duke for most ever heading into a tournament).

Key factors: - Arizona is the "safest" 1-seed pick per virtually every analyst. Three of top five scorers are freshmen but they also have experienced seniors led by Big 12 POY Jaden Bradley. - Purdue (#2 offense nationally, KenPom #8) won the Big Ten tournament — Trey Kaufman-Renn (20 pts) and Oscar Cluff (21 pts) carried them past Michigan 80-72 - Arkansas won the SEC tournament (Darius Acuff Jr. 30 pts, 11 ast in the final) — conference tourney winners have won 3 of last 4 titles - Missouri (10) gets a location break playing in St. Louis with quality wins over Florida, Vanderbilt, Tennessee - Utah State swept Mountain West regular season and tourney, 6-0 in neutral-site games. One of the most experienced rosters in D-I. - Sportsbooks have Utah State FAVORED (-2.5) over Villanova despite being the lower seed

Recommended picks: - Arizona cruises to the Elite Eight - Missouri over Miami (10 over 7 upset — location advantage in St. Louis) - Utah State over Villanova (sportsbooks agree — Utah State is favored despite being the 9-seed) - BYU over Texas (AJ Dybantsa is averaging 25.3 PPG — nation's leading scorer — and BYU is favored by 2.5-3.3 pts despite going 7-10 late. Texas is 18-14 and barely survived NC State in the First Four.) - Wisconsin vs High Point is NOT safe — HP averages 90 PPG (3rd nationally), forces 16.4 TO/game (3rd nationally), and Wisconsin allows 51.2% eFG (179th). Classic 5-12 trap. - Purdue's defense collapsed from #20 to #88 late in the season — Wisconsin (4 top-10 KenPom wins, elite 3PT shooting) can beat them in R2 - Gonzaga is missing Braden Huff (knee, doubtful R1-R2) - **Region winner: Arizona** (healthiest, most complete team in the field — but note: Tommy Lloyd is 1-3 in the Sweet 16 at Arizona)

MIDWEST REGION (Michigan's Region)

Seed	Team	vs	Seed	Team
1	Michigan	vs	16	UMBC/Howard
8	Georgia	vs	9	Saint Louis
5	Texas Tech	vs	12	Akron
4	Alabama	vs	13	Hofstra
6	Tennessee	vs	11	Miami (OH)/SMU
3	Virginia	vs	14	Wright State
7	Kentucky	vs	10	Santa Clara
2	Iowa State	vs	15	Tennessee State

Analysis: Michigan has the clearest path to the Final Four, which is why they're the betting favorite despite losing the Big Ten tournament. The bottom half could get chaotic.

Key factors: - Michigan lost L.J. Cason (ACL tear) but can still go 8 deep. They own the #1 defense nationally, anchored by 7-2 Aday Mara. However, they are 0-5 ATS since the injury, and Cadeau will be playing 35+ min/game with no backup PG. Fatigue and foul trouble are real risks by E8. - **BREAKING: Alabama's Aden Holloway arrested on felony drug charges** — suspended indefinitely, removed from campus. Their #2 scorer (16.8 PPG, 44% from 3) is OUT. Alabama is now down to 9 scholarship players with the worst defense in 56 years. - Alabama also lost its SEC tournament opener — since 1993, no champion has done that. - Iowa State (KenPom championship formula team) is a strong 2-seed with elite ball-pressure defense - Virginia has an intimidating duo of Malik Thomas and Thijs de Ridder, but their slow tempo is upset-prone (they lost to 16-seed UMBC in 2018) - Kentucky (7-seed) lost 5 of final 7 regular-season games, is only 5-11 in Quad 1 games — fading badly - Akron (29-5) is 7th nationally in scoring with an explosive offense. Three players shoot 40%+ from three. - Texas Tech lost JT Toppin (21.8 PPG, 10.8 RPG) to ACL tear and has lost 3 straight including a 22-point blowout - Saint Louis (28-5) is 2nd nationally in 3PT% — much stronger than a typical 9-seed - Miami Ohio went 31-1 (undefeated regular season) and could beat SMU in the First Four

Recommended picks: - Michigan to the Final Four, but Iowa State's pressure defense is the biggest threat (specifically targets Michigan's ball-handling weakness without Cason) - Akron over Texas Tech (12 over 5 — consensus upset pick of the tournament). Then Akron OVER Alabama in R2 (Holloway arrest + Akron's 3PT shooting vs Alabama's 230th-ranked 3PT defense = nightmare for Bama) - Santa Clara over Kentucky (data strongly supports — SCU is KenPom #35 with the 23rd most efficient offense) - Saint Louis over Georgia (SLU 28-5, 2nd in 3PT%, this is a genuine coin flip and SLU has the better profile) - **Region winner: Michigan** (but more vulnerable than any other region winner due to Cason injury)

SOUTH REGION (Florida's Region)

Seed	Team	vs	Seed	Team
1	Florida	vs	16	Prairie View A&M/Lehigh
8	Clemson	vs	9	Iowa
5	Vanderbilt	vs	12	McNeese
4	Nebraska	vs	13	Troy
6	North Carolina	vs	11	VCU
3	Illinois	vs	14	Penn
7	Saint Mary's	vs	10	Texas A&M
2	Houston	vs	15	Idaho

Analysis: This region has a fascinating subplot: Houston is the 2-seed and will have effective HOME COURT ADVANTAGE in the Sweet 16 and Elite Eight (played at Toyota Center in Houston). Houston has a Hall of Fame coach (Kelvin Sampson), roster continuity from last year's championship game run, and multiple projected first-round NBA picks.

Key factors: - Florida was humbled by Vanderbilt in SEC tournament semis — are they vulnerable? Their frontcourt trio of Haugh/Condon/Chinyelu is still overwhelming. - Houston's home-court advantage in later rounds is MASSIVE - Illinois has the #1 offense in the nation (KenPom #5 overall) — a Houston vs Illinois Sweet 16 would pit star freshmen Kingston Flemings vs Keaton Wagler (#5 and #6 NBA draft prospects) - VCU has won 16 of 17 under first-year coach Phil Martelli Jr. — strong upset candidate over UNC - Iowa (9-seed) is the MOST UNDERSEEDED team per KenPom, Torvik, and Haslametrics — favored by sportsbooks (-2.5) over Clemson despite being the lower seed - Saint Mary's is vulnerable (gave up 96 points to Vanderbilt, only 1-4 in Quad 1 games) - Vanderbilt (KenPom #12) is a sneaky-good 5-seed - Nebraska (4-seed) has NEVER won an NCAA Tournament game in program history — upset risk vs Troy

Recommended picks: - VCU over North Carolina (11 over 6 upset — even stronger now: UNC is WITHOUT Caleb Wilson, All-ACC first team, out for season with broken thumb. UNC is 5-3 without him, on a 2-game losing streak, and LAST in the ACC in 3PT defense at 38.5%) - Saint Mary's over Texas A&M is actually the CHALK pick (SMC is favored by 2.5-3.5 pts). A&M went 0-4 vs ranked

opponents. Flip our earlier pick. - McNeese is more dangerous than expected — won 10 straight, leads nation in turnover rate, steal rate, and defensive pressure (19 TO forced/game). Vanderbilt is a strong lean, not a lock. - Houston makes the Elite Eight with home-court edge at Toyota Center (confirmed) - **Region winner: Houston** (home court + elite defense + coaching = title contender. This is the single strongest pick in the bracket.)

PART 3: THE COMPLETE BRACKET — Every Pick, Every Round

EAST REGION

Round 1: | Game | Pick | Rationale | |-----|-----|-----| (1) Duke vs (16) Siena | **Duke** | Lock | | (8) Ohio State vs (9) TCU | **TCU** | Coin flip — TCU's defense (top 25 adj. eff.) and physicality give them the edge. Ohio State has Bruce Thornton (20.3 PPG) but allows 52.4% from two. | | (5) St. John's vs (12) Northern Iowa | **St. John's** | SJU is -10.5 with 85% BPI win probability. Won Big East reg season AND tourney (beat UConn by 20). Too strong despite UNI's tempo mismatch. | | (4) Kansas vs (13) Cal Baptist | **Kansas** | Kansas survives. Peterson is cleared and has played 7 straight. CBU's proximity to San Diego isn't enough. | | (6) Louisville vs (11) South Florida | **South Florida** | USF won 17 of 19. Louisville 4-8 in Q1. Caveat: USF's streak was against avg NET 158 opponents — this is a toss-up, not a lock. | | (3) Michigan State vs (14) North Dakota State | **Michigan State** | Lock — Izzo is 41-17 in R1. | | (7) UCLA vs (10) UCF | **UCLA** | CORRECTED: Bilodeau (17.6 PPG) and Dent (13.5 PPG, 7.6 APG) are EXPECTED TO PLAY — sat out Big Ten tourney as precaution only. UCLA beat 3 top-10 teams this season. | | (2) UConn vs (15) Furman | **UConn** | Lock |

Round 2: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| (1) Duke vs (9) TCU | **Duke** — Boozer too dominant | | (5) St. John's vs (4) Kansas | **St. John's** — Pitino in March, SJU underseeded, Kansas shaky (lost 4 of last 5). Peterson's conditioning is a concern. | | (11) South Florida vs (3) Michigan State | **Michigan State** — Izzo's defense is a level USF hasn't faced | | (7) UCLA vs (2) UConn | **UConn** — Hurley's championship pedigree in R2 |

Sweet 16: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| (1) Duke vs (5) St. John's | **Duke** — Boozer + depth advantage. But St. John's pushed them here. | | (3) Michigan State vs (2) UConn | **UConn** — deeper tournament pedigree under Hurley |

Elite Eight: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| (1) Duke vs (2) UConn | **Duke** — 32-2, Cameron Boozer is the best player in the tournament. Even without Foster, Duke has enough. 39 of 60 ESPN experts agree. |

WEST REGION

Round 1: | Game | Pick | Rationale | |-----|-----|-----| (1) Arizona vs (16) LIU | **Arizona** | Lock | | (8) Villanova vs (9) Utah State | **Utah State** | 6-0 neutral site, swept Mountain West, most experienced roster. KenPom and models agree. | | (5) Wisconsin vs (12) High Point | **Wisconsin** | HP averages 90 PPG and forces 16.4 TO/game, but Wisconsin has 4 top-10 KenPom wins and is the 4th-best 3PT team nationally. Wisconsin's ceiling is elite. Lean Wisconsin, but HP is live. | | (4) Arkansas vs (13) Hawaii | **Arkansas** | SEC tourney champs, Acuff is elite. But Hawaii's unique no-help defense + Arkansas fatigue (didn't get home from SEC tourney until 2 AM Monday, playing in Portland) makes this riskier than it looks. | | (6) BYU vs (11) Texas | **BYU** | CORRECTED: AJ Dybantsa averaging 25.3 PPG (nation's leading scorer), broke Kevin Durant's Big 12 tourney scoring record (93 pts in 3 games). BYU favored 2.5-3.3. Texas is 18-14 and barely survived NC State. Dybantsa is a one-man wrecking crew. | | (3) Gonzaga vs (14) Kennesaw State | **Gonzaga** | Lock — but Braden Huff (knee) is doubtful for R1-R2. Kennesaw lost their leading scorer (Cottle) to game-fixing suspension. | | (7) Miami (FL) vs (10) Missouri | **Missouri** | Playing in St. Louis = home game. 3-4 pt home-court advantage nearly erases KenPom gap. Quality wins over Florida, Vanderbilt, Tennessee. | | (2) Purdue vs (15) Queens | **Purdue** | Lock |

Round 2: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| (1) Arizona vs (9) Utah State | **Arizona** — size and physicality overwhelm | | (4) Arkansas vs (6) BYU | **Arkansas** — SEC tourney momentum, Acuff's scoring is matchup-proof. Dybantsa is dangerous but Arkansas has more depth. | | (3) Gonzaga vs (10) Missouri | **Gonzaga** — Missouri's St. Louis edge disappears in Portland for R2 | | (2) Purdue vs (5) Wisconsin | **Wisconsin** — UPSET. Purdue's defense collapsed to #88 nationally late in season. Wisconsin's elite 3PT shooting (4th nationally) exploits Purdue's worst weakness (11th-worst 3PT defense in the field). Wisconsin has 4 top-10 KenPom wins. Multiple analysts flag this. |

Sweet 16: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| | (1) Arizona vs (4) Arkansas | **Arizona** — Bradley's point-of-attack defense contains Acuff better than most. Arizona too complete. | | (3) Gonzaga vs (5) Wisconsin | **Gonzaga** — 30-3, historically lethal in March. Wisconsin's inconsistency (why they're a 5-seed) catches up. |

Elite Eight: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| | (1) Arizona vs (3) Gonzaga | **Arizona** — too big, too physical, too balanced. Gonzaga without Huff lacks interior presence. |

MIDWEST REGION

Round 1: | Game | Pick | Rationale | |-----|-----|-----| | (1) Michigan vs (16) UMBC/Howard | **Michigan** | Lock — 31.5-pt favorite. Lendeborg (ankle) says he'll play. | | (8) Georgia vs (9) Saint Louis | **Saint Louis** | CHANGED: SLU is 28-5, 2nd nationally in 3PT% (40.1%), won A-10 regular season. Georgia was 10-8 in SEC. ESPN BPI: 50.9% Georgia — this is a true coin flip, and SLU's shooting upside wins it. | | (5) Texas Tech vs (12) Akron | **Akron** | Consensus upset pick of the tournament. Tech lost JT Toppin (21.8 PPG, 10.8 RPG) to ACL, lost 3 straight incl. 22-pt blowout. Akron 29-5, 10-game win streak, three players at 40%+ from 3. 5 of 10 SBR experts picked this. | | (4) Alabama vs (13) Hofstra | **Alabama** | Hofstra is very dangerous (11 of last 12), and Holloway's arrest makes this closer. But Philon (21.7 PPG) + 91.7 PPG offense should survive R1. Barely. | | (6) Tennessee vs (11) Miami (OH)/SMU | **Tennessee** | Miami OH is 31-1 (undefeated regular season) and deserves respect, but Tennessee's talent gap holds. | | (3) Virginia vs (14) Wright State | **Virginia** | Strong favorite, but NOT a lock — one expert picked Wright State as biggest upset of the tournament. Virginia's slow tempo + 3PT reliance is upset-prone (lost to 16-seed UMBC in 2018). | | (7) Kentucky vs (10) Santa Clara | **Santa Clara** | UK lost 5 of last 7, only 5-11 in Q1, only 2.5-pt favorite. SCU is KenPom #35, 23rd most efficient offense, 17th in forcing turnovers. Data strongly supports this. | | (2) Iowa State vs (15) Tennessee State | **Iowa State** | Lock — won by 49 in Big 12 tourney |

Round 2: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| | (1) Michigan vs (9) Saint Louis | **Michigan** — #1 defense smothers SLU's shooting | | (4) Alabama vs (12) Akron | **Akron** — UPSET. Alabama without Holloway (16.8 PPG, 44% from 3) is down to 9 scholarship players. Akron's three 40%+ 3PT shooters vs Alabama's 230th-ranked 3PT defense is a nightmare matchup for Bama. | | (6) Tennessee vs (3) Virginia | **Virginia** — slow tempo grinds Tennessee down | | (10) Santa Clara vs (2) Iowa State | **Iowa State** — Momcilovic's 49.6% from 3 + ball-pressure defense is too much |

Sweet 16: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| | (1) Michigan vs (12) Akron | **Michigan** — Akron's Cinderella ends here. Michigan's #1 defense is a different level than anything Akron has faced. | | (3) Virginia vs (2) Iowa State | **Iowa State** — ball pressure and transition offense is a bad matchup for Virginia's slow tempo |

Elite Eight: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| | (1) Michigan vs (2) Iowa State | **Michigan** — #1 defense prevails, but this is the closest Elite 8 game. Iowa State's pressure specifically targets Michigan's ball-handling weakness without Cason. If Cadeau has an off night, Iowa State wins. |

SOUTH REGION

Round 1: | Game | Pick | Rationale | |-----|-----|-----| | (1) Florida vs (16) Prairie View A&M/Lehigh | **Florida** | Lock | | (8) Clemson vs (9) Iowa | **Iowa** | Most underseeded team per KenPom (#25), Torvik, AND Haslametrics. Clemson lost Carter Welling (ACL) in ACC tourney and went 4-6 in last 10. Models agree: Iowa is the better team. | | (5) Vanderbilt vs (12) McNeese | **Vanderbilt** | Strong lean, but NOT a lock. McNeese won 10 straight, leads nation in turnover rate + steal rate (forces 19 TO/game). If Vanderbilt gets careless with the ball, McNeese's pressure creates chaos. Vandy's KenPom #12 status should hold, but respect McNeese. | | (4) Nebraska vs (13) Troy | **Nebraska** | Nebraska has NEVER won a tourney game (0-8 all-time). But Troy lost 4 starters from last year and is a true 13-seed. Nebraska breaks the curse. | | (6) North Carolina vs (11) VCU | **VCU** | UNC is WITHOUT Caleb Wilson (All-ACC first team, broken thumb, out for season). UNC is 5-3 without him, on a 2-game losing streak, and LAST in ACC in 3PT defense (38.5% allowed). VCU won 16 of last 17 and swept the A-10 tourney. This is the most data-supported upset in the bracket. | | (3) Illinois vs (14) Penn | **Illinois** | Lock — #1 offense nationally | | (7) Saint Mary's vs (10) Texas A&M | **Saint Mary's** | CORRECTED: SMC is actually favored by 2.5-3.5 pts. They went 27-5, lead nation in FT%, are 12th-tallest team in country, top-10 rebound margin. A&M went 0-4 vs ranked opponents. Our original pick was swimming against the current. | | (2) Houston vs (15) Idaho | **Houston** | Lock |

Round 2: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| | (1) Florida vs (9) Iowa | **Florida** — Iowa is KenPom #25 and could make it interesting, but Florida's frontcourt is overwhelming | | (5) Vanderbilt vs (4) Nebraska | **Vanderbilt** — KenPom #12, already beat Florida and Tennessee in SEC tourney. Nebraska's tourney curse weighs heavy. Vandy is the best dark horse in the bracket at +7500. | | (11) VCU

vs (3) Illinois | **Illinois** — VCU's run ends against the #1 offense in the country | | (7) Saint Mary's vs (2) Houston | **Houston** — elite defense smotherers Saint Mary's |

Sweet 16: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| | (1) Florida vs (5) Vanderbilt | **Florida** — revenge for SEC tourney loss. But Vanderbilt (KenPom #12) is the most likely team to bust this bracket. They already beat Florida once. | | (3) Illinois vs (2) Houston | **Houston** — home court at Toyota Center + elite defense. Illinois has the #1 offense but their defense ranks outside the top 25, which is a problem against Houston's grind-it-out style. |

Elite Eight: | Game | Pick | |-----|-----| | (1) Florida vs (2) Houston | **Houston** — playing at HOME at Toyota Center. Kelvin Sampson's defense + home crowd + championship game experience from last year. Multiple experts (Seth Davis, CBS analysts) pick Houston specifically because of this advantage. |

FINAL FOUR (San Antonio)

Semifinal	Pick
(1) Duke vs (1) Arizona	Arizona — healthiest roster, most balanced team. Duke without Foster has a shortened rotation that will be exposed after 4 games. Arizona's elite defense (Top 3) contains Boozer better than anyone Duke has faced.
(1) Michigan vs (2) Houston	Michigan — battle of elite defenses. Michigan's #1 KenPom defense and 7'2" Aday Mara give them the edge in an ugly, low-scoring grind. Houston loses its home-court edge on a neutral floor in San Antonio.

NATIONAL CHAMPIONSHIP

Arizona over Michigan

Arizona's elite balance (Top 5 offense + Top 3 defense) and fully healthy roster overcomes Michigan's #1 defense. The Wildcats' size and physicality — plus 12 ranked wins — make them the most battle-tested and complete team in the field.

Known risks with this pick: - Tommy Lloyd is 1-3 in the Sweet 16 at Arizona (lost as 1-seed in '22, as 2-seed in '23 and '24). This pattern is real. - Arizona is 358th in 3PT attempts and 333rd in 3PT makes. When defenses tighten in March, perimeter shooting becomes critical. - Arizona starts 3 freshmen. No team with 3 freshman starters playing 700+ minutes has won a title since 1997 Arizona. - Poor free throw shooting (17-of-31 in Big 12 tourney game; Peat shoots 59.7%).

Why we're picking them anyway: - 33 of 60 ESPN experts pick Arizona as champion — the most of any team. - KenPom Top 5 offense AND Top 3 defense (Championship Formula). - 12 ranked wins — tied for most ever entering a tournament. - Big 12 regular season AND tournament champion (3 of last 4 national champs won their conference tourney). - Healthiest top team — unlike Duke (Foster), Michigan (Cason), or Gonzaga (Huff). - The cleanest regional path in the West.

PART 4: UPSET PICKS SUMMARY

First Round Upsets to Pick

Pick	Over	Rationale
12 Akron	5 Texas Tech	Consensus upset pick. Tech lost Toppin (ACL), lost 3 straight. Akron 29-5, three 40%+ 3PT shooters, 10-game win streak.
11 South Florida	6 Louisville	USF won 17 of 19. Louisville 4-8 in Q1. Caveat: USF's schedule was weak (avg opponent NET 158).
11 VCU		

Pick	Over	Rationale
	6 North Carolina	Best-supported upset in bracket. UNC missing Wilson (All-ACC, broken thumb), last in ACC 3PT defense. VCU won 16 of 17.
10 Missouri	7 Miami (FL)	Playing in St. Louis = home game. 3-4 pt advantage nearly erases KenPom gap.
10 Santa Clara	7 Kentucky	UK lost 5 of 7, only 5-11 in Q1. SCU is KenPom #35, 23rd most efficient offense, 17th in forcing turnovers.
9 Saint Louis	8 Georgia	SLU 28-5, 2nd nationally in 3PT% (40.1%). Georgia 10-8 in SEC. True coin flip — SLU's shooting wins it.
9 Iowa	8 Clemson	Most underseeded team per 3 independent models. Clemson lost Welling (ACL), went 4-6 in last 10.
9 Utah State	8 Villanova	Swept Mountain West, 6-0 neutral site. Models agree.

Later Round Upsets

Pick	Over	Round	Rationale
Houston (2)	Florida (1)	Elite Eight	Houston playing at HOME at Toyota Center + elite defense + Sampson
Akron (12)	Alabama (4)	Round 2	Holloway arrested (16.8 PPG gone), Bama down to 9 players. Akron's 3PT shooting vs Bama's 230th-ranked 3PT defense.
Wisconsin (5)	Purdue (2)	Round 2	Purdue's defense collapsed to #88. Wisconsin's elite 3PT shooting (4th nationally) exploits their biggest weakness.
St. John's (5)	Kansas (4)	Round 2	SJU underseeded, won Big East double. Kansas lost 4 of last 5, Peterson conditioning concerns.

PART 5: POOL STRATEGY

If you're in a SMALL pool (< 25 people)

- **Play it safe.** Pick mostly favorites. Your goal is accuracy.
- Pick 3 of 4 one-seeds in the Final Four
- Limit first-round upsets to 4-6
- Champion: Arizona or Michigan

If you're in a LARGE pool (50+ people)

- **You need differentiation.** Everyone will pick the favorites.
- Consider a contrarian champion: **Houston** (only ~5% of brackets will pick them)
- Pick 6-8 first-round upsets
- Having the right champion is worth more than getting individual games right
- A Houston title run (2-seed with home court) is high-upside and undervalued

If you're in a MASSIVE pool (500+ people)

- Go bold. You need a unique bracket to win.
- Champion: Houston or Iowa State
- Pick more upsets, especially in the East (Duke's injuries create chaos)

- The expected value of a long-shot pick increases with pool size

PART 6: ADVANCED ANALYTICS DEEP DIVE

The Four Factors (Dean Oliver Framework)

These are the four most predictive statistical categories, in order of importance: 1. **Effective Field Goal % (eFG%)** — the single most important factor 2. **Turnover Rate** — turnovers per possession 3. **Offensive Rebounding Rate** — keeping possessions alive 4. **Free Throw Rate** — FTA/FGA ratio

Underseeded Teams (Analytics vs. Seed Mismatch)

Iowa (9-seed, South) is the most underseeded team according to KenPom, BartTorvik, AND Haslametrics — they have a better average analytics ranking than nine teams seeded above them. Strong upset candidate over Clemson (8-seed).

Conference Tournament Red Flags

Since 1993, no national champion has lost before their conference tournament semifinals. This eliminates Alabama (lost SEC tourney opener) from serious title contention.

Coaching Legends in the East Region

The East Region features a murderer's row of tournament coaching pedigree: - **Bill Self (Kansas)**: 2 championships, 4 Final Fours - **Rick Pitino (St. John's)**: 2 championships, 7 Final Fours - **Dan Hurley (UConn)**: Back-to-back titles (2023-24), .750 tournament win % - **Tom Izzo (Michigan State)**: 27 consecutive tourney appearances, 8 Final Fours

Scoring Strategy Reminder

In standard 1-2-4-8-16-32 bracket scoring, your **championship pick alone (32 pts) equals all 32 first-round games combined**. Spend 80% of your analysis energy on the Final Four and champion.

Advanced Model Consensus

Multiple models (Nate Silver's COOPER ratings, KenPom, BartTorvik TourneyCast, ESPN BPI) converge on the same top tier: **Arizona, Duke, and Michigan have roughly a 58% combined chance of winning the title**. The gap between these three and the rest of the field is significant.

Hot & Cold Streaks Entering the Tournament

Riding hot streaks (pick to advance): - South Florida — won 17 of last 19 (including 11 straight) - VCU — 13-1 in final 14 games - Purdue — surging after dominant Big Ten tournament run - High Point — 14-game winning streak (longest active in D-I) - UMBC — 12-game winning streak, 38% from three during the run

Ice cold (fade these teams): - Kentucky — lost 5 of final 7 regular-season games - SMU — lost 5 of last 6 - NC State — dropped final 4 regular-season games including blowouts - UCF — lost 4 of last 5 - Louisville — 4-8 in final 12 games vs. Quad 1 opponents

BREAKING: Alabama's Aden Holloway Arrested

Alabama's Aden Holloway (16.8 PPG, 44% from 3 — their #2 scorer) was arrested on two felony drug charges. He has been suspended indefinitely and removed from campus. Alabama enters the tournament with only 9 scholarship players, their worst defense in 56 years, and now a massive hole in their backcourt. This makes Alabama one of the most vulnerable 4-seeds in recent memory.

Kansas Injury Watch

Kansas 4-seed Darryn Peterson (19.9 PPG, projected #1 NBA pick) missed 11 games due to multiple injuries — his conditioning and availability are significant concerns. He is cleared to play and has gone 7 straight games without issues, but ESPN's Seth Greenberg flagged concerns about his engagement and energy. Kansas finished losing 4 of their last 5.

UCLA Injury Update

UCLA's Tyler Bilodeau (knee strain) and Donovan Dent (calf strain) were both held out of the Big Ten Tournament as a precaution. Both are EXPECTED TO PLAY vs UCF. UCLA wins this game at full strength — Dent had the only triple-double in Big Ten Tournament history and had 78 assists with just 6 turnovers over his last 8 games.

BYU Injury Watch

BYU lost both Richie Saunders AND Dawson Baker to torn ACLs this season. They went 7-10 in their final 17 games. But AJ Dybantsa (25.3 PPG, nation's leading scorer) is a one-man army — he broke Kevin Durant's Big 12 tourney scoring record with 93 points in 3 games.

Gonzaga Injury Watch

Gonzaga's Braden Huff (knee) is doubtful for the first two rounds. This limits their interior depth and could matter if they advance deep.

UNC Missing Caleb Wilson

North Carolina is without Caleb Wilson (All-ACC first team, broken thumb, out for season). UNC is 5-3 without him and on a 2-game losing streak. They also rank LAST in the ACC in 3-point defense (allowing 38.5%). Every tournament game is on a neutral court, and all 8 of UNC's losses this season came on the road/neutral.

Clemson's Carter Welling Out

Clemson lost Carter Welling (10.2 PPG, 5.4 RPG) to an ACL tear in the ACC Tournament, further weakening their chances against Iowa.

Unusual 2026 Trend

The top six teams are all **defense-first** — this is unusual historically. Past champions have typically been offense-first. This makes Illinois (KenPom #1 offense) and Purdue (KenPom #2 offense) interesting contrarian picks, as the historical pattern slightly favors elite offenses in single-elimination formats.

PART 7: KEY STATS AT A GLANCE

2026 KenPom Top 10

Rank	Team	Seed	Offense	Defense
1	Duke	1 (East)	#4	#2
2	Michigan	1 (MW)	#8	#1
3	Arizona	1 (West)	#5	#3
4	Florida	1 (South)	#9	#6

Rank	Team	Seed	Offense	Defense
5	Illinois	3 (South)	#1	—
6	Houston	2 (South)	#14	#5
7	Iowa State	2 (MW)	—	—
8	Purdue	2 (West)	#2	—
9	UConn	2 (East)	—	—
10	Michigan State	3 (East)	—	—

Conference Tournament Champions (important — 3 of last 4 national champs won theirs)

- ACC: Duke
- Big 12: Arizona
- Big East: St. John's
- Big Ten: Purdue
- SEC: Arkansas

Sources & References

- [NCAA.com - 2026 Tournament Bracket](#)
- [ESPN - Jay Bilas Full Bracket Predictions](#)
- [CBS Sports - Expert Picks & Upsets](#)
- [Yahoo Sports - Duke's Toughest Path](#)
- [SI - Key Injuries](#)
- [FOX Sports - KenPom Trends](#)
- [247Sports - KenPom Championship Formula](#)
- [BetMGM - KenPom Rankings](#)
- [Nate Silver - 2026 Bracket Predictions](#)
- [Newsweek - 5 Surprise Final Four Teams](#)
- [ESPN - Championship Odds](#)
- [PrintYourBrackets - Historical Seed Records](#)
- [BracketOdds Illinois - Seed Advancement Data](#)